that develop all of a sudden. As the stakes are very high, they have to take decisions quickly and correctly. Counterinsurgency operations are battles fought by junior leaders and bring out the best in them.

My conviction is that there is no purely military solution for such problems. If that was possible, then by now superior military power and strategy of the West would have prevailed in Afghanistan. The most fundamental step to be taken by us is to carry out a thorough analysis of the disturbed region. We must endeavour to study the people, their history and culture, the characteristics of the terrain, the development status of the area, and consequently, the political, social, economic, ethnic, religious and other causes that have led to the situation becoming critical. Once we have deliberated on these issues we should evolve a multidimensional and multipronged strategy at the national and state level to address the problem. Unfortunately, to the uninitiated, such situations appear as military problems that will require military solutions. Nothing can be further from the truth.

It has always been my belief that the principal reason for the emergence of an insurgent movement in any region is the lack of good governance. This compels segments of society to take recourse to agitations, which are initially peaceful. However, if these go unheeded, they end up resorting to violence. It has been our experience that at times external support is provided by inimical neighbours to people in a disturbed area to stoke the fire. An important means of getting to know the 'issues espoused by the insurgents' so as to gain the sympathy of the people and enlist their support, is to get hold of and study the propaganda material, such as booklets, brochures, leaflets, and video and audio cassettes which the insurgents disseminate to the public. Some of these causes may be genuine, some mere exaggerations of issues, while many are likely to be baseless and untrue. But when uncontested or not acted upon, these facilitate the rallying of people around the banner of revolt. Furthermore, these result in a kind of brainwashing of the ignorant masses, and help the insurgents get moral, financial and logistical support, and fresh recruits for their cause. Therefore, in